

# Elena Sirotkina

## Computational Political Behavior

[elena.sirotkina@nyu.edu](mailto:elena.sirotkina@nyu.edu) | [elenasirotkina.rocks](https://elenasirotkina.rocks) | [Google Scholar](#)

### RESEARCH

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I am a political scientist using generative AI and computational methods to study political behavior at scale. My work asks how political identity organizes the way people perceive and act, and how identity can be recovered from behavioral signals and embedded inside computer-vision models.

**Fields:** computational political behavior; political communication; American politics.

**Methods:** computer vision and images-as-data; eye-tracking and gaze modeling; audio-as-data; text-as-data; generative AI and large language models; experiments.

### EMPLOYMENT

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New York University, Center for Data Science 2025–present  
Data Science Assistant Professor / Faculty Fellow

### EDUCATION

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University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill 2019–2025  
Ph.D., Political Science, 2025  
M.A., Political Science, 2022

### JOB MARKET PAPER

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**Reading Between the Eyes: A Framework for Recovering (Political) Identity from Eye-Tracking Weak Signal.** Uses computer vision and gaze data to learn political identity from the weak behavioral signal of eye tracking.

### PUBLICATIONS

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Media Choice and Audience Perceptions: Evidence from Visual Framing of Immigration in News Stories. (with Olga Gasparyan). *PLOS ONE*, 2025, 20(9).

The 2026 Europe Report of the Lancet Countdown on Health and Climate Change: Narrowing Window for Decisive Health Action. (with H. K. Kriit et al.). *The Lancet Public Health*, 2026.

The 2024 Europe Report of the Lancet Countdown on Health and Climate Change: Towards a Climate Resilient Future. (with K. R. van Daalen et al.). *The Lancet Public Health*, 2024.

How Biased Media Generate Support for the Ruling Authorities: Causal Mediation Analysis of Evidence from Russia. *European Journal of Communication*, 2020, 36(2), 183–200.

When the Party's Over: Political Blame Attribution under an Electoral Authoritarian Regime. (with Margarita Zavadskaya). *Post-Soviet Affairs*, 2020, 36(1), 36–60.

A Top-down Movement with Grass-Roots Effects? Alexei Navalny's Electoral Campaign. (with Jan Dollbaum and Andrei Semenov). *Social Movement Studies*, 2018, 17(5), 618–625.

## BOOK CHAPTERS

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Active Urbanites in an Authoritarian Regime. (with Jan Dollbaum and Andrei Semenov). In R. Smyth, J. Morris, A. Semenov (eds.), *Urban Activism in Contemporary Russia*, Indiana University Press, 2023.

Varieties of Russian Activism: State-Society Contestation in Everyday Life. (with Katie Stewart et al.). Indiana University Press, 2023.

## WORKING PAPERS

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Unpacking the Eye of the Beholder: Social Location, Identity, and the Moving Target of Political Perspectives. Develops a classifier for measuring identity-specific visual sentiment.

Vision and Division: How Partisan Identity Patterns Visual Processing of Political Imagery. (with Olga Gasparyan). Large-scale eye-tracking study of motivated visual processing across the partisan divide. *Under review*.

From Pixels to Perspectives: Audience-Specific Visual Sentiment in Political Imagery. (with Olga Gasparyan).

Visual Political Polarization: How Partisan Identity Shapes Vision and Vision Reshapes Political Commitments. Registered Report (N=608). *Under review*.

Sounds About Right: Exploring Audio Dramaturgy of Political Propaganda. Introduces the concept of audio dramaturgy as the recurring organization of auditory features in propaganda.

## WORK IN PROGRESS

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Human versus Computer Vision.

Political Face Value.

## CONFERENCES & TALKS

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APSA, Visions in Politics, PolMeth, SPAM Lab, CSMaP (2026); JAWS (2024); VWAR, APSA, PolMeth (2023); Columbia/Harriman Workshop (2022).

## VISITING APPOINTMENTS

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|                                                                                |           |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Data Science Lab, Hertie School (Berlin) — DAAD Visiting Scholar               | 2023–2024 |
| Ronald F. Inglehart Lab for Comparative Social Research, HSE — Research Fellow | 2014–2019 |
| Laboratory for Regional Political Studies, HSE — Research Fellow               | 2012–2015 |

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### GRANTS, AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS (EXTERNAL)

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|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|
| Horizon Europe (HORIZON-HLTH-2021-ENVHLTH-02-03)                          | 2023–present |
| Expenses Support Grant, Institute for Humane Studies (IHS)                | 2024         |
| Oxford LLMs Travel Grant, University of Oxford                            | 2024         |
| DAAD Travel Grant, Germany                                                | 2024         |
| DAAD Research Fellowship for Doctoral Candidates, Germany                 | 2023–2024    |
| Humane Studies Fellowship (IHS)                                           | 2023, 2024   |
| Travel Grant, IHS (×2)                                                    | 2023         |
| IHS Junior Fellow, Institute for Humane Studies                           | 2023         |
| Intensive Language Course Award (German), DAAD                            | 2023         |
| Understanding Modern Russia and Ukraine Grant, ASEEES ( <i>declined</i> ) | 2022         |
| Gibbs Fellowship, Institute for Humane Studies                            | 2022         |
| Hertie School Faculty Activity Fund Award, Co-PI                          | 2021–2022    |
| Carnegie Corporation / Harriman Institute Research Grant                  | 2021, 2022   |
| Mercatus Center Research Grant, George Mason University                   | 2021         |
| Adam Smith Fellow, Mercatus Center at George Mason University             | 2021–2022    |

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### GRANTS, AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS (INTERNAL)

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|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| James W. Prothro Student Paper Winner, UNC and SAPOR  | 2022      |
| Harold J. Glass USAF Graduate Fellowship, UNC         | 2022–2023 |
| Thomas M. Uhlman Fellowship, UNC Political Science    | 2019–2024 |
| Dissertation Completion Top-Up, UNC Political Science | 2019–2024 |
| Summer Research Fellowship, UNC Political Science     | 2019–2024 |
| Assistantship Award, UNC Political Science            | 2019–2024 |
| Graduate Tuition Incentive Scholarship (GTIS), UNC    | 2023      |
| Graduate Student Transportation Grant, UNC            | 2023      |
| UNC Priority Candidate for DAAD Research Grant        | 2022      |

UNC Departmental Summer Research Support  
Summer Research Award, UNC CSEES

2022, 2023  
2020, 2021